UNIT 6

Polity and Society in Post-Mauryan Period

Learning Objectives

- To learn the cultural influence of Greeks on India
- To know the Indo-Greek rulers and their contributions
- To have knowledge about invasion of Sakas, Pahlavis of Parthians and Kushanas from Central Asia
- To gain understanding of the importance of contact between India and Central Asia
- To understand the reciprocal influence on art and literature
- To gain insight into the magnitude of trade with Rome and its impact on economy

Introduction

In the four centuries following the death of Emperor Ashoka and the resulting decline of the Mauryan Empire, parts of India were subject to the invasion of the Indo-Greeks, Sakas and Kushanas from West and Central Asia. All of them established themselves as rulers over large parts of India. This strengthened the process of acculturation and the assimilation of foreign cultures and art forms into Indian society. It also resulted in the integration of India with the Mediterranean world and Central Asia and China through extended trade linkages.

6.1 Indo-Greek Relations

The Beginnings

India's interaction with the Greeks began with the invasion of north-western India by Alexander (327–325 BCE) and his conquest of the Punjab region. When he began his return march to the West, he left the conquered territories under provincial governors. One of Chandragupta Maurya's early military expeditions was against these foreign intruders.

Seleucus Nicator, one of Alexander's most capable generals, succeeded in making himself the master of a vast territory from Phrygia (Turkey) to the river Indus after 311BCE. Within a few years, probably around 305 BCE, Chandragupta waged a war against Seleucus and defeated him. However, this was not the savage defeat that happened to Alexander's governors. Instead, Chandragupta made a peace treaty with Seleucus. Seleucus surrendered the land he had conquered up to the Indus and received 500 war elephants in return. There is also mention of a marriage agreement. The treaty also led to the establishment of diplomatic relations between the Greeks and the Mauryan emperor. Megasthenes was sent to the Mauryan capital Pataliputra as the first Greek ambassador.

Bindusara, Chandragupta's son, continued to maintain friendly ties with the Greek kingdoms in West Asia. Greek historians refer to ambassadors sent by Ptolemy II of Egypt and to Bindusara's correspondence with Antiochus of Syria. Ashoka also continued the tradition of friendly relations with the Greek Kingdoms. His Rock Edict (13) mentions five *yona* kings,

XI History - Lesson 6.indd 77 29-02-2020 12:19:18